

SUMMARY OF *THE MERCHANT OF VENICE*



Act I

In the first lines of *The Merchant of Venice*, even before he binds himself to Shylock for Bassanio's sake, Antonio is already troubled. "In sooth," he complains,

I know not why I am so sad:
It wearies me; you say it wearies you;
But how I caught it, found it, or came by it,
What stuff 'tis made of, whereof it is born,
I am to learn;
And such a want-wit sadness makes of me,
That I have much ado to know myself.

(I, i, 1–7)

He is sad, weary, does not recognize himself, and does not know why. Salerio and Solanio, two of the young Venetian gallants who gather around him, attempting to cheer and comfort him, suggest that the cause of his melancholy is not obscure. His great wealth is in transport on the high sea: His ships are at risk from storm, piracy, and shipwreck. But Antonio rejects their explanation. His merchandise is not all on one ship but on many; the ships are not all traveling together; not all of his fortune is tied up in this year's commerce. He is not bothered by external circumstance, he says. His trouble's source is within.

Antonio may not know why he is melancholy, but his conversation with Bassanio makes the cause clear. When they meet, Bassanio does not introduce the subject of going to Belmont to seek Portia in marriage. Antonio, however, does:

Well, tell me now what lady is the same
To whom you swore a secret pilgrimage,
That you to-day promised to tell me of?

(I, i, 119–121)

Such a question, of course, is a setup, allowing Bassanio to narrate essential expository material. Bassanio has squandered money he has borrowed from Antonio through living lavishly. Unable to pay that money back, he wants to borrow another 3,000 ducats so that he can equip himself to sail in style to Belmont to woo Portia, heiress to a great fortune. But this question also reveals to the audience what is hidden from Antonio. It is apparent that he has had a previous conversation with Bassanio, before his confession of malaise, during which Bassanio told him of his desire to woo a “lady.” If the cause of his (Antonio’s) low spirit is not anxiety about losing his merchandise to the “roaring waters,” “enrobed,” like a seductive woman “with [his] silks,” might it be anxiety about losing Bassanio to a wife?

With lavish declarations of love Antonio agrees to lend Bassanio the money, promising, “My purse, my person, my extremest means, / Lie all unlock’d to your occasions.” He continues:

You know me well, and herein spend but time
To wind about my love with circumstance;
And out of doubt you do me now more wrong
In making question of my uttermost
Than if you had made waste of all I have.

No doubt Antonio means what he says, but since, by his own admission, he has “much ado to know myself,” it is fair to suggest that he may not clearly know the motive of his generosity: the wish to secure Bassanio to himself by making himself essential to him. He can keep his hold fast even in an enterprise, the courtship of a wife, which threatens to loosen that hold, if he can be essential to that enterprise. Considering the bond, moreover, to which he will commit himself for Bassanio, the words “Than if you had made waste of all I have” are decidedly ominous. Antonio does not, however, have 3,000 ducats—his ventures are at sea. He instructs Bassanio, therefore, to ask around the Rialto and find a moneylender from whom he can, using Antonio’s credit, raise the sum. Thus, in the attempt to bind Bassanio to himself, Antonio will bind himself to Shylock, and Portia, to protect her marriage bond with Bassanio, will need to find the ways to undo both those other bonds.

Scene 2 moves from Venice to Belmont and introduces Portia, whose first words echo Antonio’s first words. “By my troth, Nerissa,” she says, “my little body is aware of this great world.” There is something she and Antonio share, something they have in common, something that makes them alike—the desire to possess Bassanio. Although Antonio is at a loss to know the cause of his sadness, it is not difficult for Portia—with the help of Nerissa, a wiser companion than Solanio and Salerio—to discover the source of her malaise and, by extension, to give a hint at the source of Antonio’s. “If your miseries were in the same abundance,” Nerissa says, almost chiding her mistress for her

melancholy, “as your good fortunes are,” then there would be cause to complain. But Nerissa’s second thought is deeper: Perhaps Portia is “sick” because she has “too much.” Unlike Antonio, who rejects his friends’ suggestion, Portia confirms Nerissa’s observation. She has a wealth of young energy which she cannot venture, as much as she wishes to, but which still churns within her: “The brain may devise laws for the blood, but a hot temper leaps o’er a cold decree; such a hare is madness the youth to skip o’er the meshes.” She is overripe with desire and wishes to give herself in marriage. This pulsing desire is not to be satisfied according to her own will, however, but according to the conditions established in her dead father’s will.

Before he died, Portia’s father had stipulated a test for her suitors. To win her, the successful suitor must choose the one of three caskets that contains her portrait. One casket represents gold, one silver, and one lead. Unsuccessful suitors must quit Belmont and live out their days unmarried. From all over the world suitors come, but none Portia desires. She quickens only when shrewd Nerissa reminds her of Bassanio, who visited Belmont once when her father was still alive.

Scene 3 introduces Shylock and the host of difficulties attendant upon his being a Jew, a moneylender, and, in the eyes of everyone else in the play, the villain of the piece. He is drawn according to a stereotype and he represents that stereotype. But Shakespeare provides him with an interiority which, although it does not allow him to transcend the stereotype, presents him as an actual man *alive* within it, not merely a type who can sink beneath it. Still, he is more of a stereotype than Othello, who does not stand for all Moors, not even to the other characters in *Othello*. Othello represents Othello, a man tormented by the fact of his blackness. Shylock, in contrast, represents a type. Despite how subtly his character is drawn, and despite the fact that another Jew, Tubal, appears briefly, as if to ensure that Shylock is one among many rather than a representative of all, Shylock still represents Jews and Jewishness. (His daughter, Jessica, is presented as an anomaly, the exception that proves the rule.) Like Fagin in Charles Dickens’s *Oliver Twist*, Shylock can be used to confirm anti-Semitic conceptions of Jews. Nevertheless, Shylock is not presented as motivelessly malignant, nor Antonio as quite saintly in his Christianity. Shylock is made the motive for Antonio’s outbreaks of nastiness, and Antonio’s ungenerous ill-treatment of Shylock is presented as the cause of Shylock’s desire for revenge. As powerful an imagined character as Shylock is, the play is not necessarily about him or about the nature of Jews. He is arguably a plot device in a larger scheme. *The Merchant of Venice* is about how Portia secures her husband’s faith—not his religious faith but his matrimonial faith—which she raises to the level of religious devotion.

That Shylock becomes an actual threat to Antonio rather than a mere annoyance is the result of the bond Antonio agrees to for Bassanio’s sake, in order to finance his trip to Belmont to woo Portia. Paradoxically, being endangered

by Shylock, Antonio becomes a source of threat to Portia. After Bassanio has won her, and after she has overcome Shylock's hold on Antonio, Portia will have to lessen the strength of Antonio's hold on Bassanio in order to have complete marital possession of him. Antonio's hold is strengthened by his having risked himself as a sacrifice for Bassanio.

When Shylock is introduced, he first speaks in fragments rather than in full sentences. "Three thousand ducats," he says, repeating what Bassanio has just said and considering the matter. Unlike Antonio and Portia, who were introduced in the midst of introspection, Shylock is introduced with no interior, but rather in the pursuit of his function. Unlike Antonio, who is giving when asked, Shylock is grasping. But Shylock is not trying to overwhelm Bassanio with a show of love, as Antonio is. Shylock is merely doing business. Whereas Antonio and Portia meditate on the quality of experience, Shylock quantifies experience. How much for how long, and what guarantee? Antonio is sad, but Shylock is angry. He begins tight-lipped, but his eloquence and force of speech soon burst out. He is a coiled spring. Hate, not love, is his energy. A desire to punish rather than to possess determines him.

After Shylock has indicated he must talk with Antonio before he lends money to Bassanio, Shylock will not consent when invited to dine with Antonio and Bassanio. Declining the invitation may seem spiteful and ungracious, but Shylock is clear about his reasons. His pique is understandable. The dietary code he is bound to follow is condemned, yet he is still invited to eat—a gesture that shows Christian scorn for Jewish law and for individual persons. It is also a business invitation to dine with a man who has scorned him. That Shylock is not softened by Bassanio's easygoing manner is not surprising, nor to be held against him. How could he be? He is being used when needed by people who despise him.

That Shylock is a moneylender is not intrinsic to his being a Jew. The rules of society allowed him, as a Jew, no other course. Because of the prejudice of that society, his person and his function have become one. Antonio detests him as man, Jew, and moneylender without making distinction. Antonio condemns the fact that Shylock takes interest, that he makes money on money. Shylock's hatred of Christians is a reaction to their mistreatment of him, the result of the considerable and repeated abuse he suffers for being a Jew and for offering a service which Christians have relegated to him and of which they readily avail themselves. When Shylock reminds Antonio of how badly he has treated him in his speech beginning at Act I, scene 3, line 103, Antonio does not deny it. In fact, he asserts he will continue to treat Shylock with contempt.

Against this background of mutual animosity and anger, generated by Antonio, Shylock agrees to lend the 3,000 ducats to Bassanio without interest, but the forfeit, should Antonio be unable to repay the loan in three months, will be a pound of Antonio's flesh. Shylock relishes the possibility of revenge.

A horrified Bassanio objects, withdrawing his request, telling Antonio not to agree to that condition: “You shall not seal to such a bond for me! / I’ll rather dwell in my necessity.” But Antonio does not heed him, confident the ships carrying his wealth will have safely returned to Venice by the time the bond is due. He seems almost amused by the bargain, as if taking it more as a joke than a possibility. Such poor judgment on the part of an otherwise successful merchant—and lack of suspicion regarding a person he holds in such contempt—is telling: It suggests the force of passion weakening reason and Antonio’s wish to be irreplaceable. By binding himself so to Shylock, he is binding Bassanio to himself with the strongest possible bond, the bond established by offering to sacrifice himself for him. Portia will understand how powerful that is and how threatening to her position in her marriage.

Act II

Act II opens with Portia facing unwanted suitors in Belmont—first among them the Prince of Morocco, who chooses the golden casket and finds within it a death’s head rather than a portrait of Portia. Her second suitor, the Prince of Aragon, chooses the silver casket and is rewarded with the picture of “a blinking idiot.”

Meanwhile, Bassanio is preparing to leave Venice for Belmont. Gratiano has begged to accompany him. In addition, Lorenzo, another friend of Bassanio’s, sets out, ultimately for Belmont, with Shylock’s daughter, Jessica. On the night that Bassanio and Gratiano set sail for Belmont, Lorenzo elopes with Jessica, and Jessica takes with her a substantial portion of her father’s wealth in ducats and jewelry.

Act III

Shylock is distraught at the loss of his daughter and his ducats, but the Venetians, like Salerio and Solanio, who describe Shylock’s distress, find it grotesque and hilarious. Antonio, too, suffers a blow when the news comes that his argosies have been wrecked at sea. That puts him in Shylock’s power, for when the bond falls due, he is unable to repay it, and Shylock is determined to exercise the right forfeit bestows upon him.

Once in Belmont, Bassanio chooses the leaden casket and finds within the portrait of Portia. As a kind of clue, each casket bears an inscription on the outside. The gold casket suggests it offers “what many men desire”—but the pursuit of gold ends in death. The silver casket offers the seeker “as much as he deserve”—but a man who goes by appearances, who sees a silver surface but not the true depth, is shown to be the image of a fool. The leaden casket offers nothing: “Who chooseth me must give and hazard all he hath.” The one whom this description truly fits is not Bassanio, but Antonio, who gives and risks everything he has—his wealth, his flesh, and, even, by aiding him

in his wooing, Bassanio himself, whom he must lose to a wife should Bassanio succeed. Bassanio, in contrast, risks little. It is not *his* wealth he hazards, but Antonio's. Shylock, of course, is the antithesis of the man invoked by the leaden casket: He hazards nothing in his dealings and always has his eye on getting. For him, giving is but venturing, an investment. Ironically, this is the model that Bassanio is following in his venture to Belmont, as he makes clear in his petition for Antonio's aid beginning at Act I, scene 1, line 140. Bassanio speaks of shooting a second arrow and watching its flight in the hope of helping him find a previously lost one so he may bring them both back. By arrows, he means Antonio's loans to him.

After Bassanio has chosen correctly, Portia "commits" herself to him "to be directed, / As from her lord, her governor, her king." She explains:

Myself and what is mine to you and yours
Is now converted: but now I was the lord
Of this fair mansion, master of my servants,
Queen o'er myself: and even now, but now,
This house, these servants and this same myself
Are yours, my lord.

While this may be so formally, Portia actually never relinquishes control. She is, after all, the daughter of a father who extended his control even from the grave. Portia ends up mastering every situation and everyone in the play. As the sign that she gives herself to him, Portia gives Bassanio a ring, which signifies not only possession but also the condition upon which possession depends. "When you part from, lose, or give away" the ring, she tells him, "Let it presage the ruin of your love." Despite her gift of herself and of all that is hers, she demands to control the attitude with which the recipient views the gift. If Bassanio parts with the ring, he breaks faith with the way she is to be valued, and she will no longer be his. The condition for obtaining her, after all, was to "give and hazard all" you have.

But a part of Bassanio is reserved for Antonio, as Portia learns immediately following his triumphant choice of casket. Salerio comes from Venice, bringing with him Lorenzo and Jessica and a letter from Antonio. The latter, as Portia discerns from the increasingly pained and distressed expression on Bassanio's face as he reads it, concerns and affects him deeply. Saying she is a part of him, Portia insists he tell her what ill news he has received. In his report that the bond is forfeit, all Antonio's ships have floundered, and that Antonio must render to Shylock a pound of his flesh, Bassanio confesses his debt, describing Antonio as a "dear friend." After hearing everything, Portia asks, "Is it your dear friend that is thus in trouble?" To which Bassanio responds,

The dearest friend to me, the kindest man,
The best-condition'd and unwearied spirit

In doing courtesies, and one in whom
The ancient Roman honor more appears
Than any that draws breath in Italy.

Her response is swift and generous, but also shrewd and self-protective. She tells him that immediately after their marriage service is performed, and before they consummate their union, he will go to Venice with money enough, many times more than the original sum, and rescue Antonio, for she says that Bassanio “never shall . . . lie by Portia’s side / With an unquiet soul.” An unquiet soul is one that does not rest entirely in her. The nature of the disquiet that will haunt Bassanio is hinted at in Antonio’s letter, which begins, “Sweet Bassanio,” and concludes: “it is impossible I should live, all debts are cleared between you and I, if I might but see you at my death. Notwithstanding, use your pleasure: if your love do not persuade you to come, let not my letter.” To the end Antonio portrays himself as a pathetic sacrifice for Bassanio. It is a strategy, whether consciously deliberate or not, to bind the youth to him as strongly as his contract binds him to Shylock. “Pray God Bassanio come,” Antonio says as he is being led to jail after Shylock has refused to hear his plea for leniency, “To see me pay my debt, and then I care not.”

Bassanio departs for Venice with Gratiano, leaving Portia and Nerissa, whom Gratiano has married, in Belmont. It is not, however, Portia’s intention to remain behind. She leaves her home in Belmont to the care of Lorenzo and Jessica, sends to a great lawyer in Padua an account of Shylock’s legal case against Antonio, and, armed with his opinion regarding its merit, travels to Venice. Portia and Nerissa arrive disguised as young men: Portia as a lawyer, Nerissa as his clerk.

Act IV

In court, Shylock is obdurate in his expression of hatred for Antonio and in his refusal, at the request of the Duke of Venice, who is presiding over the court, to show him mercy and not only withdraw his action against Antonio, but also, in recognition of his losses, forgive a part of the debt itself. Shylock insists that he has justice, the law, on his side and is therefore within his rights to pursue his remedy. According to the law, then, the court rules that Shylock is entitled to a pound of Antonio’s flesh and there is no more to be done. Antonio accepts the judgment with the self-effacement of a martyr, a self-effacement which seems sure to arouse pity in others:

I am a tainted wether of the flock,
Meetest for death: the weakest kind of fruit
Drops earliest to the ground; and so let me
You cannot better be employ’d, Bassanio,
Than to live still and write mine epitaph.

It seems quite clear from his last words that Antonio is playing for Bassanio's pity and a very special place in his heart when he recommends that there can be no better thing for him to do than devote himself to treasuring his memory. It is not something Portia would appreciate.

Just at the point when Antonio's martyrdom is going to be sealed, turning him into a sort of ideal for Bassanio, worthy of devoted and loving commemoration, Portia and Nerissa enter the court in the guise of Balthasar, a young lawyer recommended by the great lawyer of Padua, and his clerk. Portia reviews the case, assents that Shylock has justice on his side, and when, after her encouragement, he still refuses to grant mercy to Antonio, she affirms his right to Antonio's flesh. As Shylock is sharpening his knife to cut into the flesh, Portia stops him, informing him and the court that whereas the bond allows for his taking a pound of flesh, no allowance is made for blood or for any amount of flesh over a pound. Moreover, Portia cites other Venetian laws which make it criminal for a stranger (a non-Venetian)—which, being a Jew, Shylock is—to conspire to take the life of a Venetian, which is what it appears Shylock has done. Shylock tries to save himself, offering simply to take the money he is owed, but it is too late. As he desired justice, his opponents announce, so he will get justice. The law provides for his execution and the seizure of his estate, but to show him the Christian mercy he refused to exercise, he will be allowed to live. In addition, half his estate will go to Antonio; the other half, upon his death, will go to Lorenzo, his daughter's Christian husband; and he (Shylock) will become a convert to Christianity. He agrees to everything, says he does not feel well, and is allowed to go home. That is the last that is seen or heard of him.

This ought to be the end of the play. Bassanio is married. So are Gratiano and Lorenzo. Antonio is rescued, and Shylock, who has been more than once characterized as a dog, has been defanged. But it is not the end, for there is Portia's disguise as the lawyer to resolve. And it might have been quickly resolved by having her pull off her lawyer's headgear and letting her own hair tumble down. Instead, there is one more trick *The Merchant of Venice* must play after the previous ones about the pound of flesh and the three caskets.

Overwhelmed with gratitude, Bassanio and Antonio offer to give the young lawyer the 3,000 ducats they did not have to return to Shylock. But Portia refuses it with pieties about being well paid by being well satisfied at having done good work. Still, Bassanio presses her to permit them to give her something, so Portia says she will wear his gloves. When he removes them and she sees his ring—the one she gave him when he chose the lead casket and she told him that parting with it was the same as parting from her—she asks for it. When he explains that it is impossible for him to give the ring and tries to explain why, she will have none of it and remarks that he has made of her a beggar by encouraging her to ask for something and then treated her like a beggar by refusing to give to her when she did ask. She leaves miffed at his refusal to part with the ring.

That might have ended it, with Bassanio proving his devotion to Portia above all. But, tellingly, it is Antonio, once Portia disguised as Balthasar has gone, who says, “let him have the ring. / Let his deservings and my love withal, / Be valued against your wife’s commandment.” He is setting himself above Portia, encouraging Bassanio to allow his imperative to trump hers—and Bassanio shows greater obedience to Antonio’s imperative than to Portia’s.

Bassanio sends Gratiano after the lawyer to give the ring to him. Portia accepts the ring; meanwhile, Nerissa plots to get the ring she gave Gratiano away from him, too. They anticipate their husbands’ clumsy and comic responses when they cannot show the rings with which they had promised never to part.

Act V

A. W. Schlegel described Act V of *The Merchant of Venice* as “a musical afterlude in the piece itself,” which Shakespeare “added,” as if it were not really integral to the play, because he “was unwilling to dismiss his audience with the gloomy impressions which Antonio’s acquittal, effected with so much difficulty, and contrary to all expectation, and the condemnation of Shylock, were calculated to leave behind them.” Schlegel summarizes the action of the last act as follows:

The scene opens with the playful prattling of two lovers in a summer evening; it is followed by soft music, and a rapturous eulogy on this powerful disposer of the human mind and the world; the principal characters then make their appearance, and after a simulated quarrel, which is gracefully maintained, the whole ends with the most exhilarating mirth.

This interpretation is, arguably, off the mark in many respects and therefore very useful as a guide for a closer reading.

The “playful prattling of two lovers” is not quite what Schlegel makes it out to be. With sweet language and courtly constructions, as if they were celebrating true unions, always repeating the introductory phrase, “In such a night,” Lorenzo and Jessica describe the plights of Troilus and Cressida, Pyramus and Thisbe, Dido and Aeneas, and Jason and Medea. These are not sweet examples of sweet love which young lovers might happily celebrate as models for their love. The stories of Troilus and Cressida and Dido and Aeneas are stories of betrayal and abandonment. The story of Medea and Jason is one of betrayal, rage, and murder. Only in the story of Pyramus and Thisbe are the lovers true to each other, but that story ends with a tragic and confused double suicide. Beneath the polish and glister, something troubling is evident. The idea of betrayal in love has been suggestively introduced. Regarding the effect of music in this “musical afterlude,” Jessica says, “I am never merry when I hear sweet music.” Music can be disturbing as well as soothing. The “simulated quarrel . . . so gracefully

maintained,” which follows upon Portia’s discovery that Bassanio gave his ring, at Antonio’s behest, to the lawyer, is in fact not simulated. Portia is absolutely earnest when she tells Bassanio, “I will ne’er come in your bed / Until I see the ring.” And all his excuses, explanations, and apologies do not move her. Only when Antonio intervenes, implicitly recognizing Portia’s right to Bassanio over his, Antonio’s, does Portia relent. The power of Antonio’s hold on Bassanio and of Bassanio’s attachment to Antonio, as well as Portia’s awareness of their tie, had been emphasized only some 35 lines before the trouble over the rings begins. Introducing Antonio to Portia, Bassanio says, “this is Antonio, / To whom I am so infinitely bound.” Portia emphasizes that she understands the force of his words, repeating the word “bound” twice: “You should in all sense be much bound to him. / For, as I hear, he was much bound for you.” There is something wry in her tone, too, suggesting she finds something awry in their attachment. When Antonio finally intervenes in the argument over the ring—in order to take responsibility for Bassanio’s parting with it and for his encouraging Bassanio to betray a sacred, ceremonial vow—he says:

I once did lend my body for his wealth;
Which, but for him that had your husband’s ring,
Had quite miscarried: I dare be bound again,
My soul upon the forfeit, that your lord
Will never more break faith advisedly.

He is promising to honor Bassanio’s bond to Portia over any other obligation Bassanio might have. And “advisedly,” although it means “deliberately,” also carries the suggestion of “by my advice.” This oath by Antonio to withdraw his claim on Bassanio constitutes the final stage in a succession of events that began with Bassanio’s selection of the right casket. Portia gives Antonio the ring and tells him to give it to Bassanio, “And bid him keep it better than the other one.” Antonio thus becomes a part, the last part, of the ceremony joining Portia and Bassanio. When he gives Portia’s ring to Bassanio, he gives Bassanio to Portia. “Swear to keep this ring,” he instructs Bassanio. After he has made this surrender, Portia informs Antonio that, contrary to what they had heard earlier, “three of your argosies / Are richly come to harbor suddenly.” With this news, she releases Bassanio from any further debt to Antonio and she indebts Antonio to her, for when he reads “for certain that my ships / Are safely” anchored, he says to her, “Sweet lady, you have given me my life and living!” The problem of Antonio’s sadness has been solved; additionally, the cause of Portia’s weariness—first her father’s intervention and then Antonio’s influence—has been removed. Antonio is restored to his community freed of an enervating desire and Portia is married in a marriage of her own definition.

KEY PASSAGES IN *THE MERCHANT OF VENICE*



Act I, i, 1–7

In sooth, I know not why I am so sad:
It wearies me; you say it wearies you;
But how I caught it, found it, or came by it,
What stuff'tis made of, whereof it is born,
I am to learn;
And such a want-wit sadness makes of me,
That I have much ado to know myself.

Antonio is speaking, complaining that he is sad but does not know why. The effect of the sadness is weariness, which implies a loss of desire to live. When he says, “What stuff’tis made of, whereof it is born, / I am to learn,” there is the suggestion that one of the things a reader may expect to discover later in the play is the cause of his malaise. Line seven offers a warning, however, that Antonio is a man who does not entirely know himself. Consequently, his actions in the play are the actions of a man who lacks some degree of self-awareness.

Salerio and Solanio suggest he is preoccupied with his merchandise, which is being transported at sea, and with the fear of shipwreck, which might scatter his wealth over the waves, but he demurs and explains that he is not worried about these things, for his goods are not all concentrated in one ship.

Act I, i, 119–121

Well, tell me now what lady is the same
To whom you swore a secret pilgrimage,
That you to-day promised to tell me of?

These are Antonio’s first words in the play to Bassanio, spoken after all their friends have gone. They suggest that the two had talked earlier in the day,

previous to Antonio's opening remarks regarding his mystifying sadness. By his question now, it is clear that Bassanio had told him of a woman whose love he wished to win. Although there is no direct, causal relationship between that earlier conversation and Antonio's sadness, there is an implicit connection—one that will be strengthened by the events of the play, which will show the magnitude of Antonio's love for Bassanio and of his desire to be predominant in his affections.



Act I, i, 122–134

'Tis not unknown to you, Antonio,
 How much I have disabled mine estate,
 By something showing a more swelling port
 Than my faint means would grant continuance:
 Nor do I now make moan to be abridged
 From such a noble rate; but my chief care
 Is to come fairly off from the great debts
 Wherein my time something too prodigal
 Hath left me gaged. To you, Antonio,
 I owe the most, in money and in love,
 And from your love I have a warranty
 To unburden all my plots and purposes
 How to get clear of all the debts I owe.

In this passage, Bassanio reveals that he is in debt and that most of his debt is to Antonio. While he says he is not troubled by having to curtail his sumptuous style of living and that his chief care is to pay Antonio back, his actual purpose in the speech is to borrow more money from Antonio and to continue living a gilded life. His speech shows that in their friendship, Antonio is the giver and Bassanio the taker—a model that will be repeated in Bassanio's relationship with Portia. It may also suggest to the reader that while Shylock profits from lending money, Bassanio lives by borrowing it.



Act I, i, 177–182

Thou know'st that all my fortunes are at sea;
 Neither have I money nor commodity
 To raise a present sum: therefore go forth;
 Try what my credit can in Venice do.

That shall be racked, even to the uttermost,
To furnish thee to Belmont, to fair Portia.

What Antonio says in this passage seems to contradict his earlier remarks: “My ventures are not in one bottom trusted, / Nor to one place; nor is my whole estate / Upon the fortune of this present year” (I, i, 42–44).

Perhaps he does not have ready cash and his “whole estate” comprises primarily merchandise. In any case, it is clear that Antonio seeks to assume the role of a man nobly sacrificed for his friend. “Racked” suggests being stretched by torture on the rack, an old instrument of torture. Antonio seems to be outwardly embracing what he is internally regretting—Bassanio’s quest for Portia.

Act I, ii, 1–2

By my troth, Nerissa, my little body is aweary of this great world.

An implicit although unidentified connection is hinted at between Portia and Antonio by the similarity of their opening words. Both are suffering from a comparable weariness, although for differing yet related causes. Each one is oppressed by a type of frustrated desire.

Act I, ii, 3–8

You would be, sweet madam, if your miseries were in the same abundance as your good fortunes are: and yet, for aught I see, they are as sick that surfeit with too much as they that starve with nothing. It is no mean happiness therefore, to be seated in the mean.

In her response Nerissa initially teases Portia regarding her good fortune, pointing out that she would actually feel as distressed as she claims if her miseries could equal her good fortune—but since they do not, Portia cannot really complain of something weighing her down. But then Nerissa turns it another way and realizes that considering the plenitude of Portia’s wealth, such overabundance is like overripeness. Portia is too full, sick with too much, as one might be sick with not enough. Nerissa’s advocacy of a golden mean, a middle ground between opposing conditions, suggests a lens through which readers may look at the central controversies between justice and mercy, between giving and taking, that give rise to the polarized debates later in the play.

Act I, iii, 9–12

Shylock: Antonio is a good man.

Bassanio: Have you heard any imputation to the contrary?

Shylock: Oh, no, no, no, no: my meaning in saying he is a good man is to have you understand me that he is sufficient.

Shylock uses the word “good” in a material sense: Antonio is a good risk because of his net worth. Bassanio uses it in a moral sense, regarding his virtuousness and the quality of his character. This difference may be seen as fundamental to the distinction between justice, which seems to be quantitative and balances the value of one thing against another, and mercy, which seems to be qualitative and regards something with its own inherent value, which must be honored.

Act I, iii, 103–167

Signior Antonio, many a time and oft
 In the Rialto you have rated me
 About my moneys and my usances:
 Still have I borne it with a patient shrug,
 For sufferance is the badge of all our tribe.
 You call me misbeliever, cut-throat dog,
 And spet upon my Jewish gaberdine,
 And all for use of that which is mine own.
 Well then, it now appears you need my help:
 Go to, then; you come to me, and you say
 ‘Shylock, we would have moneys:’ you say so;
 You, that did void your rheum upon my beard
 And foot me as you spurn a stranger cur
 Over your threshold: moneys is your suit
 What should I say to you? Should I not say
 ‘Hath a dog money? is it possible
 A cur can lend three thousand ducats?’ Or
 Shall I bend low and in a bondman’s key,
 With bated breath and whispering humbleness, Say this;
 ‘Fair sir, you spet on me on Wednesday last;
 You spurn’d me such a day; another time
 You call’d me dog; and for these courtesies
 I’ll lend you thus much moneys?’

This is one of Shylock’s bravura speeches, and if what he says is true, it casts him in a better light and Antonio in a worse light than the general attitude

shown to each of them by the others in the play. Antonio's response, "I am as like to call thee so again, / To spet on thee again, to spurn thee too," indicates that what Shylock has said is in fact true, and that Shylock understands clearly the spirit that directs Antonio's actions. At this point, the only way an audience can favor Antonio over Shylock is by subscribing to the same belief that the Jew is a noxious species of subhumanity. This is clearly not the position of the play itself.

Antonio himself has a hand in shaping the consequences of his forfeiture, not just by his past behavior but because of his present negotiations. "If thou wilt lend this money, lend it not / As to thy friends," he declares, "But lend it rather to thine enemy, / Who, if he break, thou mayst with better face / Exact the penalty."

Ambiguity is introduced in Shylock's response. It is not clear how honest and how conniving Shylock is at this moment—probably some combination of both elements. The flux of circumstance rather than the fixity of his character will determine which becomes dominant:

Why, look you, how you storm!
I would be friends with you and have your love,
Forget the shames that you have stain'd me with,
Supply your present wants and take no doit
Of usance for my moneys, and you'll not hear me:
This is kind I offer.

Bassanio exclaims, "This were kindness." Shylock then suggests the forfeit of the pound of flesh. As grim as this is, and although it is more likely the issue of malice and not merriment, it is not a fait accompli but a proposition bound to chance:

This kindness will I show.
Go with me to a notary, seal me there
Your single bond; and, in a merry sport,
If you repay me not on such a day,
In such a place, such sum or sums as are
Express'd in the condition, let the forfeit
Be nominated for an equal pound
Of your fair flesh, to be cut off and taken
In what part of your body pleaseth me.

Antonio is "Content, i' faith." He answers, "I'll seal to such a bond / And say there is much kindness in the Jew." But Bassanio objects, "You shall not seal to such a bond for me: / I'll rather dwell in my necessity." Even he sees the risk involved.

Antonio, however, is blindly overconfident, an imprudence that could not have been habitual for him to become the merchant prince he is. What dulls his reason, it is quite possible, is his compulsion to prove the extent of his devotion to Bassanio—even to the outer limits of self-sacrifice:

Why, fear not, man; I will not forfeit it:
 Within these two months, that's a month before
 This bond expires, I do expect return
 Of thrice three times the value of this bond.

Shylock's response seems fraught with ambiguity, and there is a sense of a hidden agenda:

O father Abram, what these Christians are,
 Whose own hard dealings teaches them suspect
 The thoughts of others! Pray you, tell me this;
 If he should break his day, what should I gain
 By the exaction of the forfeiture?
 A pound of man's flesh taken from a man
 Is not so estimable, profitable neither,
 As flesh of muttons, beefs, or goats. I say,
 To buy his favour, I extend this friendship:
 If he will take it, so; if not, adieu;
 And, for my love, I pray you wrong me not.

Bassanio catches the subtext, but Antonio is too lost in his dream of sacrifice for Bassanio to see it. The irony is that Shylock is motivated not only by gain, but also by the possibility of revenge for the wrongs Antonio has done him. Antonio's honest contempt for Shylock, along with his overestimation of Bassanio, prevents him from understanding the depth of resentment possible for Shylock to feel.



Act II, ii, 1–32

Certainly my conscience will serve me to run from this Jew my master.
 The fiend is at mine elbow and tempts me saying to me 'Gobbo,
 Launcelot Gobbo, good Launcelot,' or 'good Gobbo,' or good Launcelot
 Gobbo, use your legs, take the start, run away. My conscience says 'No;
 take heed,' honest Launcelot; take heed, honest Gobbo, or, as aforesaid,
 'honest Launcelot Gobbo; do not run; scorn running with thy heels.' Well,
 the most courageous fiend bids me pack: 'Via!' says the fiend; 'away!' says
 the fiend; 'for the heavens, rouse up a brave mind,' says the fiend, 'and
 run.' Well, my conscience, hanging about the neck of my heart, says very

wisely to me 'My honest friend Launcelot, being an honest man's son,' or rather an honest woman's son; for, indeed, my father did something smack, something grow to, he had a kind of taste; well, my conscience says 'Launcelot, budge not.' 'Budge,' says the fiend. 'Budge not,' says my conscience. 'Conscience,' say I, 'you counsel well;' 'Fiend,' say I, 'you counsel well:' to be ruled by my conscience, I should stay with the Jew my master, who, God bless the mark, is a kind of devil; and, to run away from the Jew, I should be ruled by the fiend, who, saving your reverence, is the devil himself. Certainly the Jew is the very devil incarnal; and, in my conscience, my conscience is but a kind of hard conscience, to offer to counsel me to stay with the Jew. The fiend gives the more friendly counsel: I will run, fiend; my heels are at your command; I will run.

With Launcelot Gobbo's character Shakespeare presents a parody compressed into a soliloquy of the old morality plays with a vice and a virtue, a good and a bad angel at each ear—as if by making fun of a morality play, Shakespeare is saying *The Merchant of Venice* is not a cut-and-dried morality play. He is not trying to teach doctrinal truth—though perhaps another kind of truth, not doctrine in its directness, but human in its complexity.

There is a secondary irony, impossible to say whether intentional or not: Gobbo's conflict comically prefigures the confusion over how much virtue and how much fault each side bears in the conflict between the Christians and Shylock.

Act II, vi, 5–19

Salerio: O, ten times faster Venus' pigeons fly
To seal love's bonds new-made, than they are wont
To keep obliged faith unforfeited!
Gratiano: That ever holds: who riseth from a feast
With that keen appetite that he sits down?
Where is the horse that doth untread again
His tedious measures with the unbated fire
That he did pace them first? All things that are,
Are with more spirit chased than enjoy'd.
How like a youngster or a prodigal
The scarfed bark puts from her native bay,
Hugg'd and embraced by the strumpet wind!
How like the prodigal doth she return,
With over-weather'd ribs and ragged sails,
Lean, rent and beggar'd by the strumpet wind!

In what seems to be the kind of idle, courtly conversation the young men of Venice enjoy practicing in order to show off their wits, Salerio and Gratiano, while waiting for Lorenzo before his elopement with Jessica, exchange truisms. The passage begins with Salerio's response to Gratiano's surprise that Lorenzo, a lover who should "outrun the clock," is late.

Gratiano observes that "All things that are, / Are with more spirit chased than enjoyed." Despite himself, Gratiano is prescient about the gallants of Venice who are now in hot pursuit of their ladies. Twice in four lines, moreover, the word "prodigal" appears. "Prodigal," tellingly, is the word Bassanio used to describe himself to Antonio at his first request for money (I, i, 129).



Act II, viii, 12–26

Solanio: I never heard a passion so confused,
 So strange, outrageous, and so variable,
 As the dog Jew did utter in the streets:
 'My daughter! O my ducats! O my daughter!
 Fled with a Christian! O my Christian ducats!
 Justice! the law! my ducats, and my daughter!
 A sealed bag, two sealed bags of ducats,
 Of double ducats, stolen from me by my daughter!
 And jewels, two stones, two rich and precious stones,
 Stolen by my daughter! Justice! find the girl;
 She hath the stones upon her, and the ducats.'

Salerio: Why, all the boys in Venice follow him,
 Crying, his stones, his daughter, and his ducats.

Solanio: Let good Antonio look he keep his day,
 Or he shall pay for this.

Salerio and Solanio recount Shylock's discovery of Jessica's elopement, narrating and imitating his desperation and keening in the street. The audience is presented the scene of Shylock's discovery, grief, and rage indirectly, filtered through the gay perspective of mocking antagonists as they laugh at his distress while recounting it. Were the scene to be Shylock's, a direct confrontation of the events, it would bring the audience inside the character of Shylock, but the play insists he be seen as an outsider.

Solanio then utters something both ominous and mitigating: He connects Shylock's future vindictiveness to this betrayal. It is clear, moreover, from lines

9 and 10, just before this passage, that Antonio was aware of it, if not directly instrumental in its execution, for Salerio reports: “Antonio certified the Duke / They [Jessica and Lorenzo] were not with Bassanio in his ship.”



Act II, viii, 35–49

A kinder gentleman treads not the earth.
 I saw Bassanio and Antonio part:
 Bassanio told him he would make some speed
 Of his return: he answer'd, 'Do not so;
 Slubber not business for my sake, Bassanio
 But stay the very riping of the time;
 And for the Jew's bond which he hath of me,
 Let it not enter in your mind of love:
 Be merry, and employ your chiefest thoughts
 To courtship and such fair ostents of love
 As shall conveniently become you there:'
 And even there, his eye being big with tears,
 Turning his face, he put his hand behind him,
 And with affection wondrous sensible
 He wrung Bassanio's hand; and so they parted.

After a scornful description of Shylock's loss of his beloved daughter and a part of his wealth, Salerio describes with tender pathos how Antonio parted with Bassanio—a similar loss, really, of a beloved and of a portion of his wealth. Notice the repeated self-sacrificial tone and attitude that Antonio assumes.



Act III, i, 50–69

To bait fish withal: if it will feed nothing else, it will feed my revenge.
 He hath disgraced me, and hindered me half a million; laughed at my losses, mocked at my gains, scorned my nation, thwarted my bargains, cooled my friends, heated mine enemies; and what's his reason? I am a Jew. Hath not a Jew eyes? hath not a Jew hands, organs, dimensions, senses, affections, passions? fed with the same food, hurt with the same weapons, subject to the same diseases, healed by the same means, warmed and cooled by the same winter and summer, as a Christian is? If you prick us, do we not bleed? if you tickle us, do we not laugh? if you poison us, do we not die? and if you wrong us, shall we not revenge? If

we are like you in the rest, we will resemble you in that. If a Jew wrong a Christian, what is his humility? Revenge. If a Christian wrong a Jew, what should his sufferance be by Christian example? Why, revenge. The villany you teach me, I will execute, and it shall go hard but I will better the instruction.

In this passage Shylock responds to Salerio's question, after it has been learned that Antonio's ships have foundered, of what good a pound of Antonio's flesh would serve him. While Shylock's response can be seen as ultimately expressing a malignant desire, the desire for revenge, it also contains within it a powerful cry from the heart against the contempt with which Antonio has regarded him. In addition, even if Shylock intends his final observation about Christian practice as malicious, it is nevertheless an apposite and applicable criticism—and hardly is there a more fitting place for it to be spoken than on an Elizabethan stage, where revenge tragedies involving none but Christians were popular entertainments.

Act III, ii, 4–18

There's something tells me, but it is not love,
 I would not lose you; and you know yourself,
 Hate counsels not in such a quality.
 But lest you should not understand me well,—
 And yet a maiden hath no tongue but thought,—
 I would detain you here some month or two
 Before you venture for me. I could teach you
 How to choose right, but I am then forsworn;
 So will I never be: so may you miss me;
 But if you do, you'll make me wish a sin,
 That I had been forsworn. Beshrew your eyes,
 They have o'erlook'd me and divided me;
 One half of me is yours, the other half yours,
 Mine own, I would say; but if mine, then yours,
 And so all yours.

Portia's "Freudian" slip of the tongue and her assertion of her love through denial of her love subtly offer an interpretive model for critics of the play, as they reveal that there are meanings hidden beneath surface meanings.

Act III, ii, 63–71

Tell me where is fancy bred,
 Or in the heart, or in the head?
 How begot, how nourished?
 Reply, reply.
 It is engend'ed in the eyes,
 With gazing fed; and fancy dies
 In the cradle where it lies.
 Let us all ring fancy's knell
 I'll begin it,—Ding, dong, bell.

This is the song that is sung as Bassanio stands in front of the caskets in Belmont, considering his three choices. It seems more than coincidental that the first three lines all rhyme with one another, and also rhyme with the word “lead.” So do the words “engend’red” and “fed.” It is open to interpretation whether this is a hint Portia is offering, as she said earlier at line 10 that she “could teach” Bassanio “How to choose right,” without being “forsworn.”

The second tercet is of the same melancholy philosophy as Gratiano’s speech regarding love’s diminution. It forecasts the need Portia will have to ensure Bassanio’s fervor after he has won her.

Act III, ii, 163–173

Happiest of all is that her gentle spirit
 Commits itself to yours to be directed,
 As from her lord, her governor, her king.
 Myself and what is mine to you and yours
 Is now converted: but now I was the lord
 Of this fair mansion, master of my servants,
 Queen o’er myself: and even now, but now,
 This house, these servants and this same myself
 Are yours, my lord: I give them with this ring;
 Which when you part from, lose, or give away,
 Let it presage the ruin of your love.

This is part of a speech Portia delivers to Bassanio, giving herself to him after he has chosen the right casket. Her words seem to place herself beneath her husband—she is a “gentle spirit,” she “commits” herself to him, and she compares him to a “lord,” “governor,” and “king.” Yet her sentiments are not entirely true, and the rest of *The Merchant of Venice* will show Portia not only

to be independent of her husband, but also to be the ruling party in their relationship. She concludes this speech by giving Bassanio the ring, which will dominate the last episode of the play and which, though ostensibly a sign of her submission to him, actually signifies his bond to her.

Act III, ii, 315–322

Sweet Bassanio, my ships have all miscarried, my creditors grow cruel,
my estate is very low, my bond to the Jew is forfeit; and since in paying
it, it is impossible I should live, all debts are cleared between you and I,
if I might but see you at my death. Notwithstanding, use your pleasure:
if your love do not persuade you to come, let not my letter.

This is the letter from Antonio, which Salerio delivers to Belmont and gives to Bassanio right after he has successfully won Portia. Bassanio reads it aloud at the end of scene 2, after Salerio has given this news, after Bassanio has told Portia of his own debts to Antonio, after he has also made it clear how strongly bound to Antonio he is, and after Portia has told him she will give him money enough to redeem the bond. In response to her question, “Is it your dear friend that is thus in trouble?” he describes Antonio as “the dearest friend to me, the kindest man, / The best-conditioned and unwearied spirit / In doing courtesies.” (The “weary” Antonio is seen as “unwearied” in giving.) Hearing all this, Portia is moved to come to his aid not only to free Antonio of his debt, but also to remove Bassanio’s debt to him, which his death would compound. She says “never shall you lie by Portia’s side / With unquiet soul.”

After all that has just occurred, the reading aloud of the letter from Antonio is either for the sake of repetition or because it contains something more than its news. Significantly, it reveals the tone of a martyr calling out for pity, “if I might but see you at my death.” It also shows the pathos and passivity, which yet veils a demand, in the beseeching line, “if your love do not persuade you to come, let not my letter.” Come to me not because I want you to, Antonio is saying, but because you want to—in other words, make my desire your desire.

Act III, iii, 35–36

Pray God, Bassanio come
To see me pay his debt, and then I care not!

Expecting to die, Antonio cares only that Bassanio be there to see it, to see Antonio pay Bassanio's debt. His death will then indebt Bassanio to him forever. The unaccountable sadness with which he began the play has been grafted to a concrete event and now made it bittersweet.

Act III, v, 78–82

Why, if two gods should play some heavenly match
And on the wager lay two earthly women,
And Portia one, there must be something else
Pawn'd with the other, for the poor rude world
Hath not her fellow.

Jessica invokes an image of being weighed on a scale in order to suggest Portia's worth. At the same time, the image of scales prefigures the scales of justice and the scales that must weigh the pound of flesh in the trial scene of Act IV.

Act IV, i, 3–6

I am sorry for thee: thou art come to answer
A stony adversary, an inhuman wretch
Uncapable of pity, void and empty
From any dram of mercy.

The Duke's introductory remarks, at the beginning of the trial over which he presides, show him both to be firmly on Antonio's side and to be highly prejudiced against Shylock. He also introduces the concept of mercy, which, the tenor of his comments reveal, is something he expects Shylock to show, but which the Christians in their treatment of him are unwilling to exercise.

Act IV, i, 14

Go one, and call the Jew into the court.

This line, spoken by the Duke, again reveals the state of mind of the court. Throughout the scene, with particular exceptions at lines 17, 174, 175, and 235, Shylock is referred to as simply "the Jew" or addressed as "Jew," rather than by his proper name, thereby diminishing the sense of him as a person. When his

name is used by the Duke or Portia, it is as a means of identifying him, as when Portia asks at line 175, “Is your name Shylock?”—but she continues to call him “Jew” thereafter.

It is also noteworthy that although Shylock is the plaintiff in the case, he is treated like the defendant. The court is assembled without him and he is brought in afterward.



Act IV, i, 34

We all expect a gentle answer, Jew.

In his opening summation of the case, the Duke sets Antonio forth in a hal-
lowed light, and implicitly compares Shylock to “stubborn Turks and Tartars
never trained / To offices of tender courtesy.” He then tells him how he is
expected to behave.



Act IV, i, 44–58

What if my house be troubled with a rat
And I be pleased to give ten thousand ducats
To have it baned? What, are you answer'd yet?
Some men there are love not a gaping pig;
Some, that are mad if they behold a cat;
And others, when the bagpipe sings i' the nose,
Cannot contain their urine: for affection,
Mistress of passion, sways it to the mood
Of what it likes or loathes. Now, for your answer:
As there is no firm reason to be render'd,
Why he cannot abide a gaping pig;
Why he, a harmless necessary cat;
Why he, a woollen bagpipe; but of force
Must yield to such inevitable shame
As to offend, himself being offended.

In discussing his response to Antonio, Shylock is actually mirroring Antonio's
response and the response of the rest of the Christians to him. He, Shylock, is
the one who is treated like a rat that must be poisoned, like the offensive pig,
cat, or bagpipe. He is returning to them what they have delivered to him. But
they are asking him to be kind to them without ever having been kind to him
in either the past or the present.

In the image of the man whose response to the grating stimulus is to urinate upon himself inadvertently, Shylock reveals the painful psychology of his response to their mistreatment. He realizes his harshness shames him, but sees it as a consequence of their effect on him and not the result of his own desire.

When the Duke chides Shylock later at line 63, saying, “This is no answer, thou unfeeling man, / To excuse the current of thy cruelty,” actually it is. The current of Antonio’s cruelty to him has never been a matter of concern for public damming. It cannot but anger Shylock, and the present opposition seems like one more expression of the imbalance he is continuously subject to. Shakespeare is not—despite the language of law and morality in this scene, or in the whole play—preaching a moral sermon, but rather exploring the interplay of human psychologies.

Act IV, i, 70–83

I pray you, think you question with the Jew:
You may as well go stand upon the beach
And bid the main flood bate his usual height;
You may as well use question with the wolf
Why he hath made the ewe bleat for the lamb;
You may as well forbid the mountain pines
To wag their high tops and to make no noise,
When they are fretten with the gusts of heaven;
You may as well do anything most hard,
As seek to soften that—than which what’s harder?—
His Jewish heart: therefore, I do beseech you,
Make no more offers, use no farther means,
But with all brief and plain conveniency
Let me have judgment and the Jew his will.

Antonio, although in softer language, shows the same contempt for Shylock that Shylock shows for him. He not only calls him “the Jew,” but also brands him with an overriding fault inherent in his very identity, comparing Shylock to a wolf and referring to his “Jewish heart,” of which there is nothing “harder.”

Act IV, i, 90–98

You have among you many a purchased slave,
Which, like your asses and your dogs and mules,

You use in abject and in slavish parts,
 Because you bought them: shall I say to you,
 Let them be free, marry them to your heirs?
 Why sweat they under burthens? let their beds
 Be made as soft as yours and let their palates
 Be season'd with such viands? You will answer
 'The slaves are ours.'

Dr. Johnson cited this passage, spoken by Shylock, in order to agree with Shylock's condemnation of the Christian practice of slavery. Shylock's logic is clear: You wish to prevent me from acting exactly as you act; you may do so because you are Christians; and I may not, according to you, because I am a Jew.

Act IV, i, 114–118

I am a tainted wether of the flock,
 Meetest for death: the weakest kind of fruit
 Drops earliest to the ground; and so let me
 You cannot better be employ'd, Bassanio,
 Than to live still and write mine epitaph.

Throughout the play, the image that adheres to Antonio is that of some sort of lamb, while Shylock is associated with rats and wolves. In this speech, Antonio once again works on securing Bassanio's affections by arousing his pity, leaving him the task of becoming Antonio's sepulcher. It is just at this dangerous moment, which threatens the integrity of her marriage, that Portia enters the court.

Act IV, i, 183–201

The quality of mercy is not strain'd,
 It droppeth as the gentle rain from heaven
 Upon the place beneath: it is twice blest;
 It blesseth him that gives and him that takes:
 'Tis mightiest in the mightiest: it becomes
 The throned monarch better than his crown;
 His sceptre shows the force of temporal power,
 The attribute to awe and majesty,

Wherein doth sit the dread and fear of kings;
 But mercy is above this sceptred sway;
 It is enthroned in the hearts of kings,
 It is an attribute to God himself;
 And earthly power doth then show likest God's
 When mercy seasons justice. Therefore, Jew,
 Though justice be thy plea, consider this,
 That, in the course of justice, none of us
 Should see salvation: we do pray for mercy;
 And that same prayer doth teach us all to render
 The deeds of mercy.

Portia's speech has often been lifted out of its context and treated like a sentimental homily embroidered on a sampler. But in its context, it emphasizes the ironic and even cruel fact that the Christians in *The Merchant of Venice* do not practice what they preach. In addition, Portia is attempting to impose Christian ideology on a non-Christian. The effect, reasonably, is to enrage Shylock rather than mollify him.

Act IV, i, 262–288

Portia: You, merchant, have you any thing to say?

Antonio: But little: I am arm'd and well prepared.
 Give me your hand, Bassanio: fare you well!
 Grieve not that I am fallen to this for you;
 For herein Fortune shows herself more kind
 Than is her custom: it is still her use
 To let the wretched man outlive his wealth,
 To view with hollow eye and wrinkled brow
 An age of poverty; from which lingering penance
 Of such misery doth she cut me off.
 Commend me to your honorable wife:
 Tell her the process of Antonio's end;
 Say how I loved you, speak me fair in death;
 And, when the tale is told, bid her be judge
 Whether Bassanio had not once a love.
 Repent but you that you shall lose your friend,
 And he repents not that he pays your debt;
 For if the Jew do cut but deep enough,
 I'll pay it presently with all my heart.

Bassanio: Antonio, I am married to a wife
Which is as dear to me as life itself;
But life itself, my wife, and all the world,
Are not with me esteem'd above thy life:
I would lose all, ay, sacrifice them all
Here to this devil, to deliver you.

Portia: Your wife would give you little thanks for that,
If she were by, to hear you make the offer.

In the midst of the drama of the bond—and connected to it—is another drama, the drama of the Antonio/Bassanio/Portia triangle. In this passage, each of the players in this dramatic triangle expresses his or her particular role, exemplifying the dramatic tension that runs through the play like an undercurrent and comes to the surface at the end of this scene.

Antonio continues to work upon Bassanio with expressions of his own pathos. When he instructs Bassanio to “Commend me to your honorable wife,” “Say how I loved you,” and “bid her be judge / Whether Bassanio had not once a love,” he actually implies a competition between himself and Portia regarding whom Bassanio ought to consider his truer love.

In the lines immediately following, Antonio reminds Bassanio that he will pay his debt “presently with all my heart,” once again referring to the sacrifice he is making and to Bassanio’s debt to him for his death.

Bassanio’s response is all that Antonio could desire, for he places Antonio above Portia and declares he would sacrifice her for him. Portia, hearing this while disguised as the lawyer, objects as the lawyer for herself. Just as she has come to the trial to dissolve the bond subjecting Antonio to Shylock, her proceedings from here on are designed to dissolve the bond subjecting Bassanio to Antonio.



Act IV, i, 448–50

My Lord Bassanio, let him have the ring:
Let his deservings and my love withal
Be valued against your wife’s commandment.

In these lines, after Bassanio has refused to part with the ring and the lawyer (Portia in disguise) has exited, Antonio, knowing the significance of the ring, instructs Bassanio to give the lawyer Portia’s ring. He expressly sets up

Bassanio's love for himself against Bassanio's love for Portia, hoping to see the scales tip in his favor.



Act V, i, 1–22

Lorenzo: The moon shines bright: in such a night as this,
When the sweet wind did gently kiss the trees
And they did make no noise, in such a night
Troilus methinks mounted the Trojan walls
And sighed his soul toward the Grecian tents,
Where Cressid lay that night.

Jessica: In such a night
Did Thisbe fearfully o'ertrip the dew
And saw the lion's shadow ere himself
And ran dismayed away.

Lorenzo: In such a night
Stood Dido with a willow in her hand
Upon the wild sea banks and waft her love
To come again to Carthage.

Jessica: In such a night
Medea gather'd the enchanted herbs
That did renew old Aeson.

Lorenzo: In such a night
Did Jessica steal from the wealthy Jew
And with an unthrift love did run from Venice
As far as Belmont.

Jessica: In such a night
Did young Lorenzo swear he loved her well,
Stealing her soul with many vows of faith
And ne'er a true one.

Lorenzo: In such a night
Did pretty Jessica, like a little shrew,
Slander her love, and he forgave it her.

What appears to be a pastoral interlude, in which two lovers celebrate their own love with allusions to classical lovers, is not what it seems. Lorenzo and Jessica are quarreling with each other using an undoubtedly elegant means to frame their sallies. Each of the cases they mention is of betrayal, except for the one (Pyramus and Thisbe) that refers to a confused double suicide. In the last example, Jessica calls Lorenzo untrue.



Act V, i, 249–256

Bassanio: Pardon this fault, and by my soul I swear
I never more will break an oath with thee.

Antonio: I once did lend my body for his wealth;
Which, but for him that had your husband's ring,
Had quite miscarried: I dare be bound again,
My soul upon the forfeit, that your lord
Will never more break faith advisedly.

Portia: Then you shall be his surety. Give him this
And bid him keep it better than the other.

Antonio: Here, Lord Bassanio; swear to keep this ring.

This passage signals Portia's victory over Antonio. By forcing the competition between them for Bassanio to come to a head through the matter of the ring, Portia maneuvers the situation in such a way that Antonio pledges himself to Portia's possession of Bassanio over his own. By giving Bassanio the ring, he gives Bassanio to Portia.

